

Feminism, Experience and Social Theory

This week - Feminism

- One aim of feminism is to challenge currently accepted views on what is appropriate (or inappropriate) in terms of the behaviour/roles/position of women in society.
- It has been argued that the more people that feminism can “talk for”, the stronger its arguments. That is to say, if feminists can demonstrate that a large number of people have been disadvantaged because of their gender, then this makes their argument more convincing.
- **The main question to address (for the essay and the exam) is whether feminism can or should attempt to talk for all women, or not. This is important, as the more people that feminism can claim to represent, the more powerful its arguments. Or maybe you disagree?**
- **Try and come to a position before your class.**
- **Developing an argument is what we want you to do in your coursework.**

First Wave Feminism

- ‘Equal rights’, liberal feminism (post-French Revolution, 1789 – to the present)
- Intellectual background: the Enlightenment.
- Reacts against: exclusion of women from universality of rights
- Focuses on: equal access for women to political life (right to vote; right to representation) and labour (equal work for equal pay)
- Key text: Mary Wollenstonecraft A *Vindication of The Rights of Women* (1792)



But why should women want to be like men?

- Is the aim of feminism simply to join the (male) club?
- Or should it aim to change the rules?
- Or to start another club?
- If you were writing an essay on this topic, you would/could come to a position on questions such as these.



Simone de Beauvoir and the move toward “Second Wave” Feminism

- **Born in 1908 died in 1986**

Writing in the 1940s and 1950s when for many women the ‘aim’ of life was to ‘marry well’ – huge constraints on work – education – life!

- Many sociologists ascribe the distinction between “sex” and gender to Simone de Beauvoir in her 1949 text *The Second Sex*
- *But*, this division is not as clear-cut in de Beauvoir’s work as is sometimes thought to be the case.
- This is not to suggest that making a distinction between “sex” and gender is “wrong”, but it does need to be approached with care.



A word on the word “gender”

De Beauvoir uses the French word “*genre*” which is translated into English as “gender”

We also have the word “genre” which means type or kind or class

These words come from the Latin word “*genus*”. *Genus* indicates a “type” or “kind”

Genus, genre, and gender (especially in the grammatical sense) indicates ways of organizing the world and our thoughts about the world according to certain arbitrary categories

This is something worth thinking about.

Back to de Beauvoir

- In *The Second Sex*, de Beauvoir states that her main aim is to ask (and respond to) the question: ‘what is a woman?’ (de Beauvoir, 1988 [1953]: 13).
- De Beauvoir argues that the question of the experience of the existence, of “woman” has not previously been addressed.
- There is a lack of thought about the status of “woman” and the lives of women.
- Often these two aspects get conflated (mixed together) – it is one role of theory to help clarify these things.

There are 3 key points to remember....

- One aspect of de Beauvoir's work is to look at and understand what is meant by the concept 'woman'
- She insists that there is no essential thing which defines what women are. Indeed – we need to be wary of definitions.
- This is what is meant by her famous phrase: **'One is not born but rather one becomes a woman'**
- **Women have the EXPERIENCE of being considered the “other” of men.**

This notion of “other” should remind us of bifurcations

- ‘humanity is male and man defines woman not in herself but as relative to him; she is not regarded as an autonomous being.... She is defined and differentiated with reference to man and not he with reference to her; she is the incidental, the inessential as opposed to the absolute. He is the Subject, he is the Absolute – she is the Other.’ De Beauvoir, 2010 [1949] *The Second Sex*: 6

Women have been made objects not subjects. This is key to “Woman’s Experience” (argues de Beauvoir)

- ‘The representation of the world, like the world itself, is the work of men; they describe it from the point of view which is theirs and which they confuse with the absolute truth.’ (*The Second Sex*: 236)



However....

- **Does de Beauvoir try to “universalize” her argument/situation?**
- **Is her account historically and social limited (she is a middle class, white, European intellectual)?**
- **Can she really describe and account for the way in which ALL women have been oppressed all over the world, in every age?**

2nd wave feminism: the personal is political

PATRIARCHY

Focus on:

- Patriarchy
- Reproduction as a form of labour
- Exploitation of women's work





<http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZjHDuvMIE>
Ss

Modernity and the Private/Public Split

- Public-private split was established with the rise of capitalism. New relations of production, new employment practices, and the establishment of factories, led to a new mode and sphere of social existence.
- The production of goods shifted from the small-scale domestic level to the large-scale, anonymous level. “Work” takes place away from the living-place of those involved. You go **out** to work. In factories. All this helped establish a new conception of what constituted the public realm.
- The dwelling-place becomes, in distinction to the world of public work, the private world and hence the modern notion of domesticity is created.
- This has implications for the experiences of women.

The Construction of the Private/Public Split (2)

- Women's role becomes the inconspicuous work of making the work of the (male) wage-worker possible through the provision of sustenance (material and emotional) in the home
- And through the production of more miniature wage-labourers (children).
- Domestic sphere becomes invisible.
- Women as wasteful consumers, men as productive workers (see, for example, Hall, 1980, Walby 1986).



Moving on...

- From first and second wave feminists we can uncover:
- The importance of different standpoints/perspectives
- How experiences can provide insights into the operations of power
- How there can be a duality to experience

Arguing for difference

Feminism until 1980s did not pay enough attention to differences between woman.

1. Universalising – presumes shared history of oppression
2. Essentialising - presumes being a woman is enough
3. Ahistorical – neglects histories of oppression that reveal, e.g. how white women have benefited from colonialism

- I am aware that I am going quite quickly and “skating over” some ideas.
- But this is, partly, because you have covered these previously (in SC 201 last year)
- What I am trying to do is put things in a certain framework
- So that you can develop your own argument...(coursework)

Black feminist thought

“Black feminist thought consists of ideas produced by Black women that clarify a standpoint of and for Black women”
(‘Learning from the outsider within’, Hill Collins, 1986: 70)

- **‘Matrix of domination’**... ‘structural, disciplinary, hegemonic, and interpersonal domains of power reappear across quite different forms of oppression’ (Collins).
- Gender does not exist “on its own”
- It is always related/produced in and through other contexts and power relations
- “Race” (or the idea of race) is equally important, if not more important, than “gender”.
- Indeed, we can’t think gender without thinking “race”
- See also Collins, P. Black Feminist Thought: Knowledge, Consciousness and the Politics of Empowerment (1990)

Crenshaw

- ‘intersectionality’ (Crenshaw) - the notion that different types of discrimination intersect and often compound experiences of exclusion and social subjugation.
- What we need from you (in terms of coursework or the exam) is to come to a position with regard to matters such as “intersectionality” and explain what its implications are for feminism.

For example -

- Collins and bell hooks both questioned second-wave understandings of the home as a site of repression and subjugation.
- We will return to bell hooks' ideas in a couple of lecture this term and next.
- But here is a taster...

bell hooks

- The oppositional gaze....in *Black Looks: Race and Representation* (Boston: South End Press, 1992, pp. 115-31)
- “When thinking about black female spectators, I remember being punished as a child for staring, for those hard intense direct looks children would give grown-ups, looks that were seen as confrontational, as gestures of resistance, challenges to authority. The “gaze” has always been political in my life ...Afraid to look, but fascinated by the gaze. There is power in looking.’ (hooks, 1992: 115)

Nancy Hartsock: “Feminist Materialism”

- **Women have shared experiences of the world and how it is. They occupy the role of being both insiders and outsiders:**
 - **They are inside as they crucial to the continuation of the current system**
 - **They are outside as they have less power within the system.**
- **It is because of this dual social role, that women’s experiences more accurately reflect the reality of the social world.**
- **Hartsock, 1983: ‘The Feminist Standpoint: Developing the ground for a specifically feminist historical materialism’ in Harding, S. 1983. *Discovering Reality*, Reidel Publishing, London, pp. 283-31 (See also, Hartsock, 1998 – The Feminist Standpoint Revisited, Westview Press, Colorado)**

- **Hartsock builds on Marx's work by saying women have been given the responsibility for certain areas of production and reproduction such as childbirth and child-rearing**
- **– whereas men have been given simply the role of producing material and financial goods.**
- **Hence:**
- **“women's lives differ structurally from those of men” Hartsock, 1983: 284**

To Read Later

- **As Harstock puts it:**
- **“just as Marx’s understanding of the world from the standpoint of the proletariat enabled him to go beneath bourgeois ideology, so a feminist standpoint can allow us to understand patriarchal institutions and ideologies as perverse inversions of more human social relations” (Harstock: 1983: 142)**

Post-structuralist feminism

Identities are NOT fixed

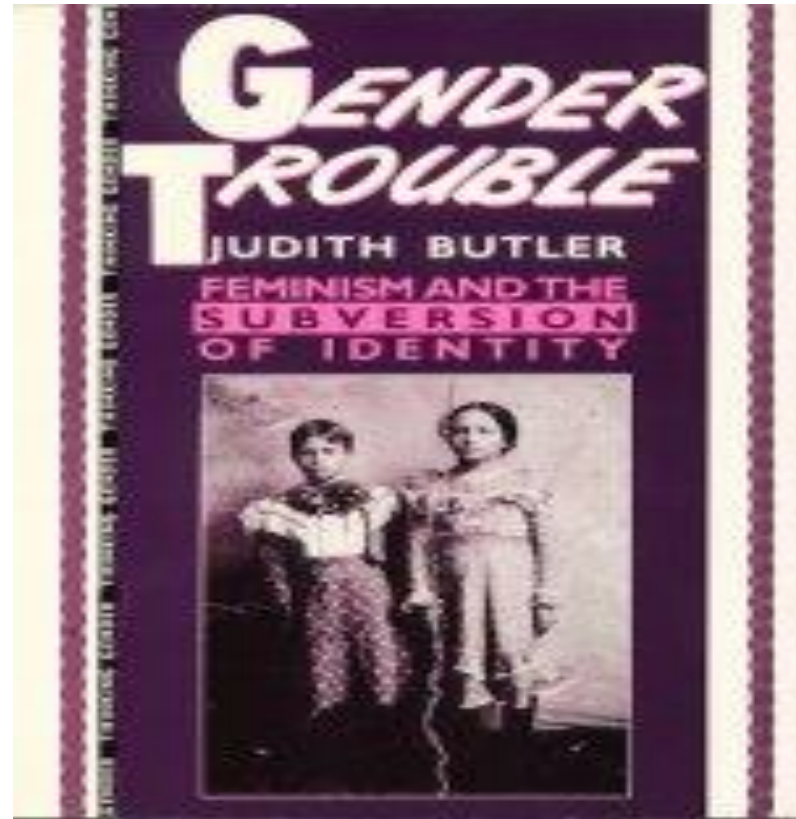
Problematifies the category of 'woman'

There is NO stable and coherent category of 'woman' (or 'man').

Terms like "sex" and "gender" are signifiers rather than stable words which refer to definite "objects" (or kinds of people).

Judith Butler *Gender Trouble* (1990)

- ‘It is not enough to inquire into how women might become more fully represented in language and politics’.
- ‘Feminist critique ought also to understand how the category of “women,” the subject of feminism, is produced and restrained by the very structures of power through which emancipation is sought.’ (p. 2)



Conclusion – The Importance of Feminism

- 1) Introduces new concepts
 - Sex – Gender
 - Essentialism
 - Birth (as opposed to male focus on death)
- 2) Points to how the world (or worlds) could be different
- 3) **The main question to address (for the essay and the exam) is whether feminism can or should attempt to talk for all women, or not. This is important, as the more people that feminism can claim to represent, the more powerful its arguments. Or maybe you disagree?**